

2b. Core Content of A Level in Music (H543)

The following core content outlines the knowledge and understanding that underpin this qualification. The content will be assessed across all components. It should be used in conjunction with the Areas of Study. This qualification requires learners to develop an in-depth understanding of musical elements,

musical contexts and musical language, and apply these, where appropriate, to their own work when performing and composing. Further details of the skills needed for the Performing, Composing and Listening and appraising components are given in Sections 2c – 2g.

Musical elements and their interdependence	• organisation of pitch (melodically and harmonically) including: ◦ harmonic change ◦ cadences e.g. interrupted ◦ melodic and harmonic devices ◦ complex chord progressions e.g. the use of secondary dominant ◦ melodic devices such as augmentation • tonality including: ◦ how keys are related to each other e.g. circle of fifths ◦ complex and remote key relationships e.g. enharmonic • structure; organisation of musical material including: ◦ complex structures e.g. sonata form, fugue and through-composed music • sonority including: ◦ combinations of vocal timbres ◦ instrumental techniques e.g. con sordino, sul ponticello • texture including: ◦ complex combinations of musical lines (parts) e.g. homophony and polyphony ◦ and more complex applications of these e.g. fugue • tempo, metre and rhythm; how music is organised in time including: ◦ metrical and rhythmic devices e.g. changing metres and syncopation, additive rhythm and polyrhythms • dynamics; use of dynamics including: ◦ expressive devices e.g. contrast and extended ranges and refined control of dynamics and extreme ranges.
Musical contexts	• the effect of purpose and intention e.g. of the composer, performer, commissioner on how music is created, developed and performed in different historical, social and cultural contexts • the effect of audience, time and place e.g. venue, occasion on how music is created, developed and performed in different historical, social and cultural contexts • how music from different historical, social and cultural contexts has changed over time.

Musical language	• reading and writing staff notation including: ◦ rhythmic notation in compound time, irregular time signatures and all key signatures • chords and associated chord symbols including: ◦ standard harmonic progressions e.g. chord inversions and dominant 7th chords ◦ extended chords e.g. secondary 7ths and 9ths • musical vocabulary and terminology related to the Areas of Study including: ◦ recognition and use of appropriate musical vocabulary and terminology e.g. glissando, repetition and conjunct; recognition ◦ use of sophisticated terminology e.g. portamento, and ascending minor scale.
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Areas of Study

Learners will study at least four areas from a choice of six Areas of Study. Learners will study Areas of Study 1 and 2 and a choice of at least two more from Areas of Study 3, 4, 5 and 6.

Through the investigation and in-depth study of the large variety of music contained in the six Areas of Study set for A Level Music, learners will further develop their knowledge and understanding of:

- the musical elements and their interdependence
- musical contexts
- musical language.

The purpose of the Areas of Study is to provide contexts through which learners will study the core content of A Level Music and explore the three key inter-related elements of:

- tonality
- interpretation
- instrumental/vocal techniques.

They are designed to encourage a musical and practical approach to teaching and learning, and to promote integration between the skills of performing, composing and appraising (listening).

The Areas of Study have been designed to be flexible to allow centres and learners to tailor the course of study to their own preferences. The centre may choose which Areas of Study to follow based on learner choice, learner ability, or teacher preference. The table below gives examples of how the Areas of Study can be combined.

	Performing	Composing	Listening and appraising	Areas of Study covered
Example 1	Learner has free choice - applies knowledge of skills, techniques and interpretation to free performance choices.	Learner studies Area of Study 2 and chooses composition brief related to Area of Study 2 .	Area of Study 1 and 2 compulsory. Learner studies and chooses questions related to Area of Study 3 and Area of Study 4 .	1, 2, 3 & 4
Example 2	Learner chooses a recital programme related to Area of Study 6 .	Learner studies Area of Study 6 and chooses composition brief related to Area of Study 6 .	Area of Study 1 and 2 compulsory. Learner studies and chooses questions related to Area of Study 3 and 6 .	1, 2, 3 & 6